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The Public

Every jazz-lover has two or three clear, old-fashioned, rose-tinted pictures in the family album of his hobby. One is of the classic New Orleans street parade: the musicians on their cart, cornet blazing, trombone sitting on the tailgate so that the slide moves freely, 'going to town' as the Basin Street whores leave their cribs to listen, the kitchen mechanics come to the doors tapping and shaking, and the conjure women stop selling their spells. Another is of the dance hall somewhere across the tracks: black faces on snappily dressed bodies, and the throb of the horns over the drum. A third is the 'rent party' in the slums of the Chicago South Side or Harlem: pigs' feet, beer, whisky, and the hypnotic rhythm of the piano:

*Give the piano player a drink because he's bringing me down.
He's got rhythm: when he stomps his feet
He sends me right off to sleep.*

A fourth is certainly of the honky-tonk: a big man at the upright piano with a derby hat, men with drinks, girls and their pimps—themselves, as like as not piano players or pool-room sharks, or both—and the cry: 'Play that thing, mister, oh, play that thing.' When the words 'the jazz public' are mentioned, it is images like these which come most naturally into the minds of the aficionados. Mistakenly so. For though it is true that the first and original public for jazz was of this kind, it is also, from our point of view, the least interesting. For jazz is peculiar in having acquired a 'secondary' public far vaster than its primary one. It is rather like the city of Venice, in which the foreign visitors in any year now greatly outnumber the native Venetians. Naturally the relationship of the natives to their city is interesting; but it is much less odd, and for that reason

much less puzzling, than the relationship of the outsiders who do not belong there but have taken it to their hearts.

The vast majority of those who have enjoyed jazz since 1914–18, when it became a national American, and subsequently an international, phenomenon, were and are outsiders in one way or another. This applies less to American blacks and a section of Southern whites than to the rest of us, for, as we have seen, poor and uneducated blacks used a primitive or preparatory form of the jazz idiom in their normal folk-music, secular or religious. Hardshell believers from the Carolinas, used to praising the Lord in their way, would find nothing strange in jazz:

‘When James P. [Johnson] and Fats [Waller] and I would get a romp down shout going’, says the famous Harlem pianist Willie ‘The Lion’ Smith, ‘that was playing rocky just like the Baptist people sing. You don’t play a chord to that—you got to move it, and the piano players do the same thing in the churches, and there’s ragtime in the preaching. Want to see a ring shout? Go out to the Convent Avenue Baptist Church any Sunday.’¹

It was not jazz, but anyone who spoke this musical idiom would have as little trouble learning jazz as an East Anglian has in learning standard English. In a sense all first-generation urban blacks in the U.S.A. can be regarded as part of the ‘primary’ public of jazz. For ideological reasons some of them—notably the very religious or respectable—might not like it, but it was their music nevertheless. The black public for jazz therefore presents us with a rather different problem from the white public, at least until it comes to contain a large percentage of second-generation urbanized blacks, or of blacks with social and cultural aspirations which make it look down on the old-fashioned idiom in which it has been brought up, or on the simple jazz which emerged directly out of this idiom.

Not so the whites. In the cities of the North and, *a fortiori*, in those of Europe, jazz was a new language. It is pretty certain that it made its way first and foremost through the ballroom. Until the eve of the Second World War the pioneers of jazz among the secondary public had invariably been the dancers, and, as we have seen, the early history of

jazz expansion can virtually be written in terms of the active and rhythmical dances to which it provided a uniquely suitable accompaniment. The cake-walk prepared the way for ragtime; the one-steps, two-steps, and foxtrots for jazz. When Benny Goodman, the 'King of Swing', tried to explain why his style of jazz became so popular, he naturally observed: 'It was a dancing audience—that's why they went for it'.² The true-blue jazz-lover, who looks down with contempt on commercial pop music, and would not dream of actually dancing to his favourite music unless his girl insisted on it—and then only as a concession to cultural backwardness—is a late phenomenon. As a type he has emerged out of the mass of swaying couples who did not look for creative art in the places where jazz was played, and whose main reason for liking jazz was that it was good to dance to. If we ask a middle-aged jazz-lover how he came to like the music, we shall very likely get the answer this writer got from a Newcastle schoolmaster in his forties, who has been an amateur since about 1930:

You see, when I was young, I used to go out dancing a lot, and it got me interested in the music. Of all the dance music I heard, jazz seemed the liveliest, and the one with most to it. Then I started to buy records.

For similar reasons the dance musicians themselves were drawn to 'pure' jazz, even in countries such as Britain, where their native idiom was quite different, and where indeed a peculiarly formal and extremely popular dance style evolved in the 'palais' which sprung up between the wars. 'Strict tempo' dancing, the foundation of the mass ballroom vogue among the British working class, with its contests and championships, grew in a direction diametrically opposed to jazz. Yet when, in 1932, a knowledgeable British journalist wrote about the jazz public, he estimated—no doubt with some exaggeration—that ninety-five per cent of it consisted of dance-band musicians.

For jazz was not merely good to dance to. Of the mass of commercial pop and dance music, whether or not it was coloured by the jazz idiom, 'pure' jazz was the most interesting to play or to listen to, the one least

likely to pall. A middle-aged jazz critic has recalled his school-days in 1926–7, when he first acquired a taste for it:

The father of one of the boys was a director of H.M.V., so we got all the new records as they came out. We played them over and over again, naturally. After a few months I found that I got bored with most of them, but the “hot” records stood up. That is how I first suspected there was something to jazz.

The ‘jazz fan’ emerged from the run of the popular music mill, because ‘hot’ jazz itself emerged from the competition with ordinary semi-jazz dance music as something worth special attention.

The jazz-lover in the strict sense of the word thus emerged from the mass of the ordinary public for dance and pop music by a sort of natural selection; but he is no more like that public than men are like the apes from which they have evolved, a comparison which, though unfair, springs readily to the mind. As a type he has always and everywhere had clearly recognizable characteristics, the first of which is his stubborn refusal to be confused with the ‘pop’ fan. He is passionately ‘anti-commercial’, to the point where the mere fact that an artist attracts the larger box-office is often regarded as *prima facie* evidence of musical treason, or even where the musician who dresses properly for his stage appearance may get black looks from the more incorruptible fans. The fan is not normally happy except among initiates. To quote a characteristic passage from two of them:

The collector, despite the revival [of interest in jazz—EJH] can *still take some solace* from the fact that if you seriously ask the head clerk of any large record store, he will tell you that John Q. Public might be getting a little more hep, but there has been no sweeping change for the better—the huge majority still come out starry-eyed for the latest Dinah Shore. The collector’s clubhouse at the private country club is a lot more crowded than before *but it still has a homely atmosphere* [my emphasis—EJH].³

Perhaps for this reason the fan, even within jazz, has limited tastes. Middle age, history, and vested interest have by now created a certain number of catholic or eclectic jazz-lovers, but this does not come naturally. For the characteristic fan, jazz, like the ideal blood of an aristocratic family, is a sharply defined stream in constant danger of pollution from the muddy floods which surround it. 'What is jazz?' is the single question which crops up most frequently in the discussions of the aficionados. It is neither pop music nor 'straight' music. Normally it is not even everything which falls between these two territories, assuming the jazz fan to have defined their vague boundaries to his satisfaction. There is also a particular type of the 'true' jazz which must be defended against its impure, or deviationist, or obsolete competitors. In the 1920s and early 1930s 'white' jazz fought 'black' jazz; in the middle and late thirties 'big-band jazz' also fought 'small-combo jazz'. Since the Second World War this civil war has become institutionalized in the battle between the traditionalists and the modernists, each camp also containing sub-camps whose members have the firm conviction that most of their colleagues have sold the pass. The rights and wrongs of these discussions need not concern us here: they are not all stupid. It is their Calvinist spirit that counts, whether expressed in the sophisticated accents of the critics or the simple cries of 'Treason' by teenagers whose favourite jazz bands decide to play in a different style.

Jazz, for the fan, is therefore not simply a music to be enjoyed as one enjoys apples, or drinks, or girls, but one to be studied and absorbed in a spirit of dedication. Jazz fans do not listen to their music to dance, and often avoid dancing, unless pressed into it by their girl friends, whose approach to the music is normally more utilitarian. They stand or sit by the bandstand, soaking in the music, nodding and smiling at one another in a conspiracy of appreciation, and tapping their feet unless the expression of any overt emotion is conventionally frowned on. (In the peak days of the feud between ancients and moderns, a reliable way of telling one from the other in Anglo-Saxon countries was by the fact that the ancients favoured a more Bacchic style of appreciation, while the moderns, imitating the *avant-garde* musicians, kept a dead face; however, among traditionalists the aficionados of the blues have always tended towards a rather church-like gravity. In Latin countries, and notably in

France, the contrast was less, owing to the traditional enthusiasm of all local art-lovers for demonstrating their cultural allegiance by breaking up the concerts of rival art-lovers.) Jazz, for the true fan, is not merely to be listened to, but to be analysed, studied, and discussed. The quintessential location of the fan is not the dance hall, the night club, or even the jazz concert or club, but the private room in which a group of young men play one another records, repeating crucial passages until they are worn out, and then endlessly discussing their comparative merits. For every jazz fan is a collector of records, within his financial means. Flourishing communities of fans have come into being in countries such as Britain, at times when virtually no live jazz of interest was to be heard at all, almost purely on the basis of records, and there are many fans (such as this writer) who at an earlier stage of their career listened to no live jazz at all for something like ten years on end.

Moreover, the fan is not exclusively interested in jazz as music. For him jazz is a world, and often a cause of which the actual sound emerging from the instruments is only one aspect. The lives of the musicians, the environment in which jazz evolved, the political and philosophical implications of the music, the scholarly or sporting details of discography, are equally part of it. It is not merely due to the lack of musical literacy among jazz fans that technical discussions of jazz in musical terms have been so rare, nor to the strong Marxist influence of the 1930s that so much of jazz criticism and jazz appreciation consists, in effect, of writing or studying the social history of jazz ‘up the river from New Orleans’, or even more fundamentally ‘across the water from West Africa’. This mixture of aesthetic, social, philosophical, and historical interests is part of the make-up of the jazz fan. Only since the Second World War has something like ‘pure’ musical or aesthetic appreciation or criticism of jazz emerged as a serious force, and then only among one school of jazz-lovers. Biographical and historical material, studies of individual bands, discographies, discussions about the nature of jazz, impressions of the jazz scene, re-creations of the social atmosphere of jazz, and record reviews have always provided the bulk of the content of the specialist jazz magazine, in the pages of which a line of music-print is as rare as Hebrew or Chinese characters in the ordinary book.*

The jazz fan is therefore rarely a musician himself. (Periodicals addressed to the amateur and professional musician are recognizable by the spate of articles of the type 'How to get the best out of your trumpet', 'How to improvise a chorus', and the like; these do not often occur in the specialist magazines.) It is true that enthusiasm for jazz has always been rife among amateur and professional dance musicians, that is, among a fairly large public, for the American Federation of Musicians, aided by an insurance expert, estimated that in 1953–4 there were 19,114 jazz pianists busy every night in the U.S.A., not counting amateurs. (In case this figure should mislead, it may be mentioned that the number of 'classical' or academic pianists of 'superior ability' at this time was estimated as 114,684.)⁴ It is also true that an enthusiasm for jazz has always tempted a good many fans to try their hand at playing: the 'revivalist' movement in jazz was primarily a movement of amateurs, even if many of them have since become professionals. Lastly, it may be true that in the early stages of the jazz movement, the proportion of fans who were also players, or who became players, was high: much higher than that of lovers of painting who paint, lovers of classical music who play, though perhaps not higher than that of lovers of poetry who also write verse, which is a rather unskilled occupation. We do not really know, for there are no figures, but it is not at all unlikely. However, it seems quite clear, both from experience and from the contents of the specialist literature, that the practising or aspiring musician rapidly became a small minority of the jazz public, which consisted, and consists, overwhelmingly of 'appreciators'.[†]

Broadly speaking, this description is true of the jazz public anywhere and at any time: I have no doubt that it applies to the hot and cool communities of Tokyo, Reykjavik, and Buenos Aires as much as to those of Los Angeles and London. But who composes these communities?

Statistics are difficult to come by. Among the few we have are those of a sample collected by a gramophone company in the Paris region in 1948 (at the height of the local jazz boom).⁵ According to this inquiry twelve per cent of the record-buying public were in the market for jazz (thirty per cent of those under the age of thirty), sixty-nine per cent of the

jazz-record buyers were young—under thirty—and their social composition was as follows:

	<i>Per cent</i>
Middle class	34
White-collar	22
Tradesmen, shopkeepers	7
Students	4
Working class	26
‘Collectors’	4
Musicians	2
Foreigners	1

In brief, jazz in France was (and, to judge by subsequent inquiries such as those of the review *Arts*, is) a minority addiction, the addicts being in majority young—though with a surprisingly high proportion of older people—and overwhelmingly members of the lower-middle and middle classes.

On the whole this impression is probably universally true, though with considerable national variations. There is no doubt at all that jazz is, and has always been, a minority taste, even allowing for those who appreciate hybrid and jazz-influenced music which the purists refuse to admit. This is true not only of France, where jazz-record buyers lagged far behind those of classical and operatic music (twenty-three per cent) and even farther behind such native European forms of light entertainment as *chansons*, variety, accordion and *bal musette* music, and operetta (a total of fifty per cent), and only just equalled ‘dance music’ (twelve per cent). It is equally true in Britain where (before the jazz boom of the last five years) the best-known British ‘revivalist’ jazz band could reckon with an average sale of only 5,000 copies of each of its 78-rpm records, and the company which released the works of Jelly-Roll Morton was surprised and gratified to find that this acknowledged and advertised hero of old New Orleans sold 3,000 to 4,000 copies per (78-rpm) disc. Jazz has until recently simply not been big business in Britain, in the terms in which those who prepare records for the ‘hit parade’ of the

‘top ten’ or ‘top twenty’ think of it; or even normally in the terms in which a regular steady seller in the popular music market—say Mr Victor Silvester, Mr Stanley Black, or Mr Jimmy Shand of the Scottish music, think of it. This is why it has so largely been left to marginal or amateur enterprise, and even today, when it has become profitable, it can at best be described as small to medium business. We may estimate the size of the ‘strict’ jazz public as somewhere between the 25,000 or so who buy *Jazz news* (specialist jazz books sell 8,000 or so) and the 115,000 who buy the traditional weekly of the jazz-lover, the *Melody Maker*.⁶ True, these are the hard core of the strict jazz public, and they are surrounded by a penumbra of people who, though neither regular readers nor record buyers, probably go to the occasional concert or buy the occasional record. But even if we assume that all those who visit the concerts of a famous American band, say Count Basie’s, are jazz-lovers, and that such a band plays to capacity throughout its tour, the national jazz public at present hardly amounts to more than 100,000 or so: say 20,000 in London, 60,000 in the rest of the big cities covered, and the balance in the neglected towns.⁷ Such figures are not negligible, but they are those of a minority public. this does not mean that such a minority may not become a majority, though this is unlikely, for the young people, among whom the great bulk of the jazz addicts are to be found, are themselves always a minority, except in rather exceptional demographic situations. Britain is a fairly extreme example, for the jazz public here is proportionately much larger than in most other countries, with the exception of the Scandinavian ones and perhaps the Dutch; proportionately larger than in France, and certainly than in the U.S.A.

Admittedly, both in Britain and in the U.S.A. jazz-tinged idioms of popular music are very much more popular than in France, Germany, or Italy, where the native forms of light music have—at least until the rise of rock-and-roll—been much more resistant, because quite differently based. It may even happen that strict jazz artists or records become temporary best-sellers in the Anglo-Saxon world for this reason (i.e. that in America they sell upwards to 250,000, in Britain upwards of 100,000 copies, as things stood in 1958). However, though jazz-influenced pop music must belong to the world of jazz as the historian sees it, it is not

jazz as either the musician, the sociologist, or the businessman sees it. It has the same relation to jazz as Palm Court string groups have to classical music: at best the low-brow version of the high-brow article, at worst a mere background noise. As the children in a California high school, devotees of pop music in its most heavily rhythmical versions, put it: 'Jazz is a sophisticated kind of entertainment, isn't it?'

The second equally undeniable fact is that the jazz public is overwhelmingly young—and masculine. Among whites, jazz is essentially a music appealing to boys and young men between the ages of, say, fifteen and twenty-five.[±] (The post-war commercial offensive against school children may have lowered this age-level a little, but probably not much. Instrumental jazz is not children's but young adults' music, and the children influenced by it are more likely to take to simple vocal music of the rhythm-and-blues or country-and-Western type.) This observation requires no statistics. In jazz clubs and at jazz concerts young men invariably preponderate, because very few girls go there except with boy friends, while very many boys also go there alone or with other boys. The actual community of addicts is almost totally masculine. Though there are enthusiastic and knowledgeable aficionadas among women—normally on the fringes of the intellectual or artistic occupations, or of night life—closer research will almost always show that they have acquired the taste through an earlier boy friend among musicians or fans. This is fairly easy, for the jazzman is both a passionate proselytizer, and a keen follower of the women. Of all the arts in mid-twentieth-century Britain, this is so far the one with the overwhelmingly strongest heterosexual tradition and ethos, in spite of the almost unlimited toleration of jazzmen for deviations and idiosyncrasies in people's private lives.[§]

It is equally clear that a good many youthful jazz-lovers abandon their enthusiasm once they reach maturity. This may be partly for material reasons: married men cannot afford to buy records on the scale of single men, nor are they encouraged to go to all-night dances, clubs, and other jazz occasions. But there is more to it than this. The wild passion and effervescence of jazz fits in with adolescence. Young people find it easier than mature ones to overlook the formal and emotional limitations of

jazz, or even its frequent mediocrity, for they pour into it their own emotion, vitality, and dedication to make up for the shortcomings of the music. To the eye of passion, coloured glass can look like diamonds, and much of jazz (though not the best of it) is no more than musical glass cut in so suitable a form as to reflect the light of its public with the utmost brilliance. At all events, the curve of jazz enthusiasm in men's lives takes a sharp turn downwards from about the middle twenties on. Older men either drop their interest in jazz entirely—the records are played increasingly rarely, and perhaps eventually sold—or settle down into a less passionate pattern of appreciation; unless they become professionally concerned with jazz in some way or another.

The older fan exists, for even on the most pessimistic assumptions each generation of addicts formed since the late 1920s is bound to have left some residue of permanent jazz-lovers. Often, indeed, a flare of jazz enthusiasm among the young may awaken the dormant enthusiasm of the middle-aged: jazz is not old enough to have really ancient addicts. Normally, the older jazz-lover has a less exclusive and demanding allegiance to his music: he can take it or leave it alone. An occasional concert or club—provided the audiences are not so overwhelmingly adolescent as to make him feel alone—an occasional session playing and discussing old records with contemporaries ('just like old times'), arguments with his children on their unaccountably bad jazz taste, a quiet quarter of an hour with the American Forces Network jazz broadcasts late at night: these are about his limits. The stuff can still move him. At worst, the sound is pleasant and part of his life, at best he knows that for certain moods and emotions there is no more poignant equivalent than a good jazz record. Jazz, for the older amateur, is like the occasional dose of lyric poetry for the man who has long ceased to read poetry systematically, a nucleus of surviving youth. The older jazz-lover is not simply, as André Hodeir suggests, young at heart. He may quite well, like Yeats, know that he is not, but also know what youth (including his own) is about:

*Labour is blossoming or dancing where
The body is not bruised to pleasure soul,
Nor beauty born out of its own despair,*

*Nor blear-eyed wisdom out of midnight oil.
O chestnut tree, great rooted blossomer,
Are you the leaf, the blossom, or the bole?
O body swayed to music, O brightening glance,
How can we tell the dancer from the dance?*

The social composition of the jazz public presents a more complicated problem and national variations of greater significance. It may be worth looking at a few countries in greater detail.⁸

Paradoxical though it may seem, the specialized jazz public in the U.S.A. has always been relatively, and probably absolutely, smaller than in Europe, though the public exposed to some kind or other of jazz has been much larger. The sales of the British *Melody Maker* are considerably higher than those of the equivalent American weeklies. As for the demand for jazz records, *Billboard* gives the following statistics for the early 1950s.⁹

	<i>Per cent</i>
Popular music	49.1
Classical music	18.9
Country and Western	13.2
Rhythm and blues	5.7
Children's records	10.2
Foreign folk-music	1.1
Latin-American	1.0
Hot jazz	0.8

Virtually only the last item represents the 'pure' jazz public for while most of rhythm and blues (the ancestor of the recent rock-and-roll craze) is jazz, its normal public is among the unself-conscious black buyers, not the self-conscious jazz appreciators. The same is true of the very much less jazz-tinged, but very 'folky' country and Western music (hill-billy, cowboy music, and the like). Admittedly it is likely that 'popular music' includes a certain amount of jazz of the more saleable kind, but even so the jazz public must trail a very long way indeed behind the public for

classical music. The American jazz fan is therefore a rather exceptional specimen.

In the U.S.A. the (white) jazz-lovers seem to have come first, as a group, from among the Northern middle-class youth, that class being defined as those who went to college between the wars. The South has produced proportionately very much fewer fans and collectors, no doubt for the obvious reasons. At all events American universities have played a disproportionately large part as nurseries of jazz music. The history of the white 'Chicago' musicians of the 1920s can be written in terms of college dances, and notably of student taste at Indiana University. Eastern colleges provided the staple public for the earliest 'swing' bands, notably the Casa Loma Orchestra. The students of the University of California (Los Angeles) turned Goodman's first tour into a success, and those of Berkeley and Stanford were later to provide the backbone of the early West Coast 'revival' bands.¹⁰ Since the war it has become axiomatic in the business that blues and high-brow jazz can be made to sell best on the 'college circuit' but even in the colleges jazz still remains a minority taste, though a large one.[¶]

There is equally little doubt that the first group in history which shows most of the characteristics of the modern aficionados, the white 'Chicago' musicians of the middle 1920s, was primarily a white-collar or middle-class group. (They differ from the modern fan chiefly in that most of them became actual players.) Bix Beiderbecke, Hoagy Carmichael, the 'Austin High School Gang' (McPartland, Teschemacher, Lanigan), Dave Tough, Floyd O'Brien, Pee-Wee Russell were from the right side of the tracks, as is indicated by the absence of Italian and Slavonic names among them. Mid-Western jazz was not confined to middle-class boys, though it is significant that the only working-class school to have produced a marked jazz tradition of its own was the highly untypical Hull House School, the Toynbee Hall of Chicago, i.e. a foundation of middle-class social workers.^{||} At all events, the young Chicagoans had all the essential fan's stigmata: the desire to play and hear, not jazz but the only true jazz, the painstaking and dedicated copying of an entire style, the occasional idealization of the black (most notably in Milton Mesirow, who at least claims middle-class origin),¹¹ the occasional deliberate

declassment, the intellectual interests and pretensions—Bix fancied Debussy and Schoenberg—and the obvious revolt against middle-class respectability:

‘It was little Dave (Tough)’, writes Mezzrow, ‘who gave me the knock-down to George Jean Nathan and H. L. Mencken. ... Dave used to read *The American Mercury* from cover to cover, especially the section called *Americana* where all the bluenoses, bigots, and two-face killjoys in this land-of-the-free got the going-over they never forgot. That *Mercury* really got to be the Austin High Gang’s Bible. It looked to us like Mencken was yelling the same message in his magazine that we were trying to get across in our music; his words were practically lyrics to our hot jazz.’¹²

Systematic record collecting first seems to have begun among the ‘college crowd’ in the later 1920s.¹³ The pillars of the early hot clubs in the middle thirties were middle-class intellectuals—the daughter of a wealthy Canadian manufacturer, a lawyer, a future English don, and the like. The most influential and active patron of jazz in the thirties was (and is) a radical offshoot of an extremely wealthy and respectable Eastern family. Similarly Howard Becker, who has described a group of modern Chicago jazz aficionados in one of the few sociological studies on the subject, correctly draws attention to their middle-class characteristics: they are sons of old, respectable, comfortable Anglo-Saxon American families who deny their birthright for the company of horn players and honky-tonk girls and the aesthetics of low life. Theirs is a political protest, for ‘they reject the American way of life *in toto*’, though without substituting anything for it but music, *avant-garde* existentialist philosophy, and a personal anarchism, which is perhaps why those of them who do not wreck themselves by this life and die early will probably end, like their predecessors, as respectable bourgeois, except for a few who become musicians, or revolutionaries. Jazz was, and is, for deviant American members of the middle class what surrealism and existentialism were for deviant French members of it.

These were the handful of pioneers. A larger American public of pure jazz enthusiasts only appeared among the high school youths in the

middle 1930s rather later, and probably on a rather smaller scale, than the comparable public in Europe. Both the first journals appealing specifically to the jazz public (*Down Beat*, 1934) and the first Hot Clubs (Chicago 1935) were younger than their European opposite numbers. The jazz revival of the war years added another batch of recruits, so that by 1944–5 the American record collectors' community consisted mainly of two sectors: those in their later twenties, who had been converted in the middle thirties, and those just about twenty, who had been converted in 1942–4.¹⁴ It is certainly still overwhelmingly middle class and overwhelmingly between the ages of twenty and forty, the younger group supporting mainly rhythmic pop music, the older ones never having been fully exposed to jazz or having abandoned it. A market research report (1960) on a California radio station which plays jazz exclusively makes this quite clear: 79.4 per cent of its listeners were between twenty and forty, 90 per cent had attended or were attending college, only 6.6 per cent were craftsmen, 4.5 per cent 'operatives and kindred workers'.¹⁵ Whether this public is as overwhelmingly on the political left as the jazz fans of the New Deal vintage, among whom there were probably very few Republicans, we do not know.

Apart from the political and ideological changes among the young post-war Americans of the age-groups which produce most jazz fans, there is no great evidence that the composition of the jazz community has changed much.

However, the American jazz public has two important peculiarities. In the first place it contains a far larger and wealthier section of adults than the European. These lawyers, doctors, business executives, scientists, or newspapermen, now on the verge of middle age, have never recovered from the musical infection of their youth. While the kids maintain the jazz club or concert, it is people of this kind who maintain the 'Dixieland' clubs where elderly men also play as though the world were young, and who give to the American night-club an atmosphere so different from the European, breeding jazz-impregnated singers, jazz-impregnated and socially corrosive satirists. They also provide that most adult of jazz artists, Duke Ellington, with the public he needs; for his appeal to the adolescents is not too strong. Such men give to jazz the nearest thing to

patronage it possesses. Is it accidental that some clubs most firmly associated with middle-aged mobsters systematically hire good jazz groups, not because they give better profits, but because they *like* jazz? Nor is this public negligible. Even in 1960, when the pop music market was largely determined by the teenagers, twenty to thirty per cent of the selections on American juke-boxes were 'composed of records by artists who appeal through nostalgia and familiarity to the strictly adult market' and 'most of the records of these bands—Glenn Miller, Artie Shaw, Benny Goodman, the Dorseys—are between fifteen and twenty years old.'¹⁶

This leads us to the second peculiarity of the American jazz public. It is this. Whereas jazz came to Europe through the regulated channels of American record imports, which were in turn controlled by the pioneer aficionados and critics, who therefore imposed their own tastes and standards on the wider public, jazz in America was live music, which altogether escaped minority intellectual control. Except for very small groups of rigid sectarians, the line between the 'pop' and the 'jazz' public in America was therefore much hazier than elsewhere, the power of commercial advertisement to interest a marginal public in whatever band or style happened to be in vogue was immeasurably greater. To judge by the periodic 'polls' which the jazz press has conducted since the middle 1930s, European taste has (until the later 1950s) fairly consistently reflected the taste of the critics, even to the point of remaining faithful throughout the years to artists whose achievement in jazz critics believe to be permanent. American taste, on the other hand—perhaps because it depends less on records and more on the temporary prominence of live musicians—has been notoriously changing and fickle: in fact, even the American 'true' jazz public has behaved far more like a pop public than has the European.

This may be illustrated by the choice of the best trumpeter. Virtually every European poll since the beginning has consistently placed Louis Armstrong first, and even after the split between the 'traditionalists' and the 'modernists', has bracketed him with the leading modern trumpeters Gillespie or Miles Davis. American polls have successively placed a

variety of trumpeters of very uneven merit at the top, in some instances even failing to place Armstrong in the first ten.^{**}—

The Continental public has also been markedly middle-class and intellectual, probably more so than in America. It is also by far the oldest consistent and organized jazz public in the world. The first Norwegian jazz club seems to have been founded as long ago as 1928, and though the journal *Le Jazz Hot* did not appear in France until 1935, by 1933 there were magazines dealing mainly or wholly with jazz at least in Holland, Sweden, Belgium, Switzerland, France, and Germany. On the Continent jazz had the advantage of fitting smoothly into the ordinary pattern of *avant-garde* intellectualism, among the dadaists and surrealists, the big city romantics, the idealizers of the machine age, the expressionists, and their like. Thus in France Jean Cocteau and Max Jacob patronized *Le Jazz Hot*, while Marianne Oswald, the favourite *disease* of the intellectuals, singing poems about down-and-outs and prostitutes by Prévert, did so to ‘serious’ jazz accompaniments. After the war the theoreticians of modern jazz published their discussions about it in Sartre’s *Les Temps modernes*. This self-confidence, and the Latin proclivity for writing manifestoes, probably explains why France became the intellectual headquarters of jazz criticism before the middle thirties, dominating the taste of jazz-lovers through the periodically revised writings of M. Hugues Panassié and the activities of collectors through the *Hot Discography* of M. Delaunay, as today it does the aesthetics of modern jazz criticism through M. André Hodeir. The French might know a great deal less about actual jazz than the Americans who were on the spot; they might indeed patently know too little to write full-dress books, as was the case with M. Panassié’s pioneer *Le Jazz Hot* (1934), virtually all of which was abandoned by its author within five years. But the proverbial Gallic certainty and lucidity saw them through, and the rest of the world listened.

In Britain the situation was rather different, and in many ways more interesting. Here too, the growth of the jazz public passed through the usual stages. Until 1927 the ‘true’ jazz fans were merely a handful of scattered individuals, but in 1927–8 a recognizable jazz public emerged, strong enough to make it worth the gramophone companies’ while to

release a regular supply of American ‘hot’ records, mainly of the white New York variety. An attempt to issue a series of primarily black records failed, since even the ‘hottest’ aficionados found them too strong for their tastes, at least if we are to judge by the contemporary record reviews.^{††} Again, to judge by the record releases, this public remained steady and grew throughout the next years, apparently quite unaffected by the slump which for a time virtually destroyed recorded jazz in the United States. Indeed, as we have seen, some of what little survived in America was virtually commissioned for the European—i.e. mainly the British—market. By 1933 the British jazz public was large enough to make a large-scale London recital for ‘serious’ jazz fans, by a visiting American band, financially possible: Duke Ellington’s London concert at the Trocadero, Elephant and Castle. Until then, and for a long time thereafter, visiting artists relied on ordinary music-hall and dance bookings, i.e. on attracting a much wider public than that of the jazz aficionado: the appearance of the jazz concert, like the specific jazz club, marks the emergence of the jazz public as an independent force.

Large or small, the British jazz-lovers became increasingly self-confident during these years. Their first articulate prophet had been an energetic young Spaniard, Fred Elizalde, who formed the first ‘pure’ British jazz band from among Cambridge undergraduates in 1927; Oxford, as usual the home of lost causes, held back. Their second, and far more influential one, was a cosmopolitan young Irishman with a fortunate combination of musical and literary talent, who has described his early career charmingly and fully.¹⁷ Mr. Patrick ‘Spike’ Hughes formed a recording band, played, composed and, most important of all, in 1930 took over the jazz-record reviewing in the *Melody Maker*, which henceforth became the bible of every British jazz-lover. At about the same time the British fans also began to develop the characteristic institution of the ‘Rhythm Clubs’ which multiplied rapidly after 1933. By the end of 1935 ninety-eight had been formed, of which perhaps fifty were really active. Their main centre was in and around London (which alone contained upwards of twenty), in the south, and in a few scattered large cities. They do not seem to have penetrated the north and Scotland in force until rather later, and Wales hardly at all.^{††} The middle thirties

also saw the first of those little specialist journals which are as much part of the world of jazz as of that of poetry.

The jazz public was small. I do not suppose many jazz records sold more than 1,500 copies. It was also, in spite of the impeccable social setting of prophets like Elizalde and Hughes, overwhelmingly drawn from the lower-middle and working classes. The established upper and middle classes—those who went to public schools and universities—were far less important in it than their opposite numbers were in America and on the Continent. The working-class contingent among British jazz-lovers came chiefly from among, or turned rapidly into, dance-band musicians. These were, as we have seen, a group of markedly proletarian origins, which always contained a core of jazz enthusiasts. Indeed, their trade journal complained in 1927 that they ‘pandered to their own tastes rather than the public’s in playing too much “hot” music’.¹⁸

Probably, however, the people to whom jazz made its strongest and most direct appeal came from that social zone in which the sons of skilled workers, probably themselves in office jobs, met the sons of white-collar workers, shopkeepers, small business men, and the like: from the ‘lower-middle class’. Clerking, small business, the drawing-board, accountancy, commercial art, the lower reaches of journalism, the fringes of show business, provided the jazz-lover’s professions: anyone who knows ‘fans’ of the 1930s, can immediately think of three or four accountants or commercial artists. They were cultural self-made men. The respectability against which they revolted was that of the semi-detached suburban three-bed, two-reception house; but they also resented, and revolted against, the world of upper-class culture, as reached through the public school and ‘varsity. If H. G. Wells had been in his teens in the early 1930s, he would have attended the first Rhythm Clubs, and met others like himself, for the jazz fans came from his world. This is probably why the young post-1945 writers, who, led by Kingsley Amis and John Wain, gloried in what purported to be ‘provincialism’, wrote jazz among the many other rude words on their banners. They were fifteen or twenty years late in discovering it, but their instinct was right.

Theirs was, by and large, the world of the grammar school and public library rather than the public school and university; of the teashop and

Chinese restaurant, rather than the sherry party; and when times were bad, as they were in the thirties, sometimes of the fish-and-chip shop. They were not against official culture. Jazz for them was not, as for many Continental intellectuals who took to it, a retreat into unintellectualism. On the contrary, it was part of achieving intellectualism the independent way (and often the hard way) by self-education. American and Continental 'hot' and 'rhythm' clubs spent much of their energy making or sponsoring live jazz. The British ones were not so interested in this—there is no British equivalent to the Quintet of the Hot Club of France or the Dutch Swing College Orchestra of the thirties—but they spent a great deal of time discussing jazz and its social background and history. The early fans' taste in the orthodox arts did not differ significantly from the official taste: if 'high-brow', they read their Eliot, Pound, and Empson and their D. H. Lawrence, though also their Oscar Wilde and Bernard Shaw and, as like as not fifteen years before the rest of the high-brows, their science fiction in pulp magazines. No doubt jazz appealed to them because it was *their* discovery and art, not that of the upper-class cultured; but it also appealed to them because, thanks to its immediate appeal, it was an ideal introduction to serious music for people with no previous qualifications and training. If they progressed to classical music, as like as not they did so via Delius, whose sensuous appeal is equally direct, and especially Debussy, whose *Après-midi* provided the bridge to the classics for more than one fan. It is easy for those who come from intellectual environments, and have gone through the full educational treatment, to forget that even the teenage sons of Oxford dons start on Bach and Piero della Francesca not because these have a powerful appeal to their age-group, or even make much sense, but because there is considerable tacit pressure to the effect that they are high-class things, which one ought to think well of.

The pioneer jazz fan was therefore culturally active, energetic, often with ambitions to create: perhaps one reason why commercial artists, journalists, people on the fringes of the theatrical and film business were so frequently found in his ranks. A Mr Clifford Kellerby, a bus conductor, was not at all untypical in his extra-curricular activities: he played in both jazz and military bands, edited the *Leeds Transport Magazine*, drew posters, painted (we owe our information about him to a large, and, alas,

not very successful symbolic painting on the past, present, and future of jazz)¹⁹, and ‘travelled on the Continent’. I have very little doubt that he also composed a fair amount of poetry in free verse. If less ambitious, he very likely still had the hobbyist’s and collector’s itch, which found an outlet in the compilation of elaborate and scholarly discographies, the collection of biographical material, and experiments (if he had the money) with elaborate gramophone equipment. He was almost certainly politically conscious, because the appreciation of jazz implied, at its minimum, views about racial discrimination, i.e. Fascism. In the 1930s this meant almost invariably that he was on the extreme left, being joined in this situation by the young, unemployed musicians who were pushed there by unemployment, the young Jewish ones who were pushed there by Hitler. Not that the left recognized the jazz fan as a type; but he was in it all right and gave all jazz made in the pre-Second World War mould a permanent slant to the extreme left.⁸⁸

From the middle thirties jazz began to permeate upwards into higher society, and notably into some of the public schools and the old universities. To judge by my own memories of Cambridge in the last pre-war years, its conquests were modest. An enthusiasm for jazz or the blues was a respectable eccentricity, but nevertheless neither normal nor socially particularly cherished. It affected some (but not all) of those who idealized Roosevelt’s America and most of what came out of it, but not to anything like the extent to which, say, American films gripped us. It did not belong markedly to the Auden-Spender-Isherwood-*New Writing* phase of literary enthusiasm, which dominated the Spanish Civil War years. The first really jazz-struck bunch I can recall at Cambridge were those in or on the fringes of the Communist Party in the immediate pre-war years, but whose tastes took them towards the neo-romantic, quasi-surrealist kind of poetry (the ‘New Apocalypse’, Dylan Thomas, etc.) which was to dominate the forties: the Rousseauists, rather than the Voltaireans among us. It is among friends of this kind that I remember sitting entranced, not only by Mahler (another of their ‘discoveries’), but by Basic and Rushing, Turner and Johnson, and above all by Billie Holiday’s *Strange Fruit*: by the jazz of 1938–9 vintage.

This modest expansion of the jazz public reflected the vogue for 'swing' which swept the United States after 1935 as well as the political currents of the times. But swing put the older, and more quintessential, British jazz-lovers into a quandary. The jazz community exists largely, as we have seen, by its exclusiveness and its hostility to commercialism. Swing was popular and commercially successful. The ranks of the aficionados were therefore shattered by ideological civil wars between purists and impurists, a war as usual easily won by the purists. Their taste—which came to dominate the taste of the jazz public, for the pioneer fans became in their turn the writers and critics—can be roughly defined as favouring any jazz appreciated by them before 1935, or made in a pre-1930 idiom, with a marked preference for that played by black players. Mr Rex Harris's Pelican books on jazz still reflect this attitude, heightened by the later New Orleans fanaticism, with remarkable accuracy. The strength of this purism was all the more remarkable, because it was not only rationally and musically indefensible, but not shared by the leading critics and sponsors of jazz. M. Panassié, with all his increasing passion for the pure gospel of New Orleans, welcomed every new discovery of the swing era with his customary ebullience and good taste: Billie Holiday, Lionel Hampton, the Lunceford Orchestra. Mr John Hammond in America, who discovered and launched virtually every musician and band of importance in the swing era, was himself a bitter opponent of commercialization. The Purists were pure, not because they were told to be, or because they could justify themselves, but because sectarian exclusiveness was in their blood.

It was therefore natural that the extraordinary expansion of the jazz public which took place everywhere during the war, was not the direct prolongation of swing, but a reaction against it: the 'New Orleans Revival'. In Britain, and indeed everywhere else, this is difficult to analyse in purely social terms. It was an age-group, rather than a particular social stratum, which received the revelation from Jelly-Roll Morton and King Oliver: the boys who were between fifteen and twenty-two years around 1945, though some of their leaders, and all their critical mentors, belonged to the generation of the 1930s. Out of fifteen leading British 'revivalist' musicians one (the first of them all) was born in 1917, three in 1920–1, two in 1926, and nine in 1928–32—six of them in 1928–

9.^{¶¶} All of them came from among the jazz fans, none from among the professional musicians. Their social origins were mixed: public schoolboys and university students took to 'revivalism' as readily as anyone else. However, the centre of gravity of the movement undoubtedly lay in the suburbs, especially those of London, increasingly infiltrated by the skilled working class. The 'revivalist' jazz bands formed on the outskirts and marched upon the centre of the city, like rebellious armies deposing Roman emperors. George Webb's Dixielanders raised the banner of revolt in the Red Barn at Bexleyheath, Kent, in 1944, the 'Crane River Jazz Band'—nursery of numerous New Orleans prophets—came from Cranford, Middlesex, while to this day the Jazz Club Calendar of the *Melody Maker* records the strongholds of the music in Chadwell Heath and Southall, Croydon and Wood Green, Ealing, Hanwell, Harringay, and Dagenham. Soon Leeds produced the Yorkshire Jazz Band, Manchester the 'Saints' (named after the tune which may best be described as the national anthem of the revivalists, *When the Saints Go Marching In*), Liverpool the [sic] 'Merseysippi Band', while from Scotland there came, as usual, a stream of musicians. Why the Scots have taken to jazz so much more readily than any other part of Britain is obscure, but the fact is not in dispute: ever since the early and middle thirties they have provided by far the largest single contingent of good jazz musicians in these islands.

To judge by the character of the London fans, the lower-middle-class youth pretty certainly remained the main pillar of the jazz public. Nevertheless the general atmosphere of revivalism in this country (as distinct from America and the Continent) was rather more 'proletarian' than that of earlier jazz fashions.^{¶¶¶} Possibly this is due to the fact that—as we have seen—the revival movement was much more of a *playing* movement than earlier fashions, and much more home-based. Its heroes were not so much the great and often defunct New Orleans black players. These were rather gods whom mortals discerned as through a glass, darkly, for their battered acoustical records of the 1920s often sounded so appalling that a great deal of faith was needed to recognize their merits. (This was even more true of some of the old men who were resuscitated for the benefit of the young white public: nobody except a historian

would have listened twice to poor Bunk Johnson's recordings, which were to be an inspiration to countless youngsters.) The public for revivalist jazz in Britain was soon built of admirers of Humphrey Lyttelton, Ken Colyer, and Chris Barber rather than of King Oliver and George Lewis, of those who knew Otilie Patterson (of Newtownards, Northern Ireland) and Lonnie Donegan (of Glasgow) rather than Bessie Smith and Huddie Ledbetter, whom these singers imitated scrupulously. And the 'jazz club' of the 1940s and 50s was not, like the Rhythm Club of the thirties, a place of self-education, where records were heard and dissected, but essentially a place where live jazz by British musicians was encouraged and admired. The revivalist public was therefore less 'learned' than its predecessors, and less 'intellectual'.

At all events, the social tone of the movement was set by the amateur and semi-professional musician, and the ordinary inexpert fan, generally of schoolboy or student age. This kind of simple, non-intellectual music had its appeal to the intellectuals, not to mention young aristocrats from the gossip-column zone. It captured the art students, the young actors, the young writers, especially those who also discerned in it the latent but undefined revolt which they themselves felt. It is no accident that revivalist jazz provides the incidental music to John Osborne's *Look Back in Anger*, whose hero, it will be remembered, occasionally goes off-stage to practise the trumpet and once had ambitions to become a jazz trumpeter. However, for quite different reasons, it also increasingly and obviously captured the provincial working-class youth. In Glasgow, in Belfast, in Newcastle, the Mississippi, musically speaking, was in full flood, and those who swam in it were primarily working-class youngsters.***

Revivalism remained a minority phenomenon, though by the middle fifties there were probably few grammar schoolboys, attenders of youth clubs, and other youth organizations who had not become familiar with it. Oddly enough, in spite of the general change in the political climate, it retained strong links with the Communist left, partly no doubt for historical reasons. Few of the leading revivalist bands were without some Communists, and several were led by young men who came out of, or from the neighbourhood of, the small Communist youth movement,

while the International Youth Festivals of 1947–57 were also international rallies and propaganda platforms for revivalist jazz. However, an equally, if not more strongly, leftist offshoot of the revival gave birth to a virtually universal musical vogue among young Britons: ‘Skiffle’ (1956–8). This may best be regarded as a modification of revivalist jazz to suit an even more completely unqualified and lay public. The movement was quite spontaneous. Left-wingers had long pioneered ‘ballads and blues’ sessions on both sides of the Atlantic, and produced a modest cabaret political and *avant-garde* vogue for artists like Josh White, Leadbelly, Burl Ives, Woodie Guthrie, Pete Seeger—or in Britain, Ewan McColl and Isla Cameron. Revivalist bands in Britain had taken to allowing a guitarist-singer with rhythm accompaniment to sing such blues and songs (mainly from the Leadbelly repertoire) between band sets: the arrangement was called ‘skiffle’, a term dug up from the obscurer recesses of American jazz history, and virtually without meaning for anyone in the U.S.A. A taste for the blues had long been part of a sound revivalist approach, though commercially a hopeless proposition. Of all jazz fans, the blues-lover has been the most consistently esoteric. To this day the admirer of Sonny Boy Williamson or Bessie Jackson, Roosevelt Sykes ‘The Honeydripper’, or Lightning Hopkins, must rely on imported and second-hand American records, for it has not been commercially worthwhile to release a representative selection of blues records in Britain.⁺⁺⁺

How and why this sort of material, hitherto confined to folk-song collections and the ‘rhythm and blues’ catalogues of American record companies, conquered the public, is obscure, but by the middle of the 1950s it had done so both in America and in Britain (under the respective names of ‘rock-and-roll’ and ‘skiffle’). Nobody created or anticipated the fashion: Mr Lonnie Donegan in Britain, whose *Rock Island Line*—originally a black prison-camp song—exploded into the big time in the spring of 1956, had made the record as part of his routine duties with a leading revivalist band. His version of the song had been available for almost two years. Indeed, Leadbelly’s original record had been available for the better part of a decade. The rise of the rock-and-roll stars in America was similarly unpremeditated, though premeditation by astute

business men like Colonel ‘Tennessee’ Tom Parker and Mr Hank Saperstein (who took in hand the fortunes of Mr Elvis Presley) soon came. However, if the general trend of taste was similar on both sides of the Atlantic, the British version showed two important peculiarities. Firstly, it was much more patently an outgrowth of the revivalist jazz movement. Second, it became as much a movement for amateur music-making as for listening; indeed, the largest movement of its kind within living memory. Within a few months the country was covered with a network of skiffle groups, consisting of guitars and rhythm instruments improvised out of washboards, thimbles, tea-chests, and the like, and accompanying youngsters who shouted the songs of Tennessee prostitutes, Mississippi convicts, and Alabama gamblers in what would have been a hybrid accent if the listener could have recognized it. Skiffle was unquestionably the most universally popular music of our generation. It broke through all barriers except those of age. Between the ages of eight and eighteen there can have been few inhabitants of Britain, whatever their class, education, or intelligence—down to the half-wits—who did not, for however short a period, take some active pleasure in it. The mind of the student reels as he attempts vainly to chart the frontiers of the appeal made by simple, shouting, thumping music of this type; for a Welsh farmer, who substituted rock-and-roll records for the classical ones with which he had always soothed his Friesians, discovered that their milk-yield went up by five gallons a day.^{[20](#)}

Revivalist jazz, as we see, progressed steadily, and with increasing speed, from minority to majority status. By the later fifties it had virtually ceased to be minority music: skiffle was triumphant. But even after it had exhausted its short vogue, the old-fashioned instrumental jazz of New Orleans remained stronger than ever. It had, indeed, insensibly turned into standard popular dance music for youngsters between fifteen and twenty-five, who, if asked, would have guessed that King Oliver was the monarch of Denmark. This tendency was not confined to Britain.^{[21](#)} Inevitably, therefore, the true aficionados searched for more esoteric positions to occupy. Some fled farther back into the recesses of black folk-music, until smoked out of them by the cloud of rock-and-roll

shouters. Others fled forward, into the unexplored territories of 'modern' or 'cool' jazz.

Modern jazz had been on the American and European scene since the middle forties. Its sectarian appeal would no doubt have made itself felt earlier but for two facts: it was much harder to listen to than the older kind, and the bulk of the established critics and jazz intellectuals, formed in the school of the thirties, were bitterly hostile to it, for political and social reasons. What they cherished in jazz was a 'people's music'—that is, a music which both appealed to ordinary people and, in its nature, provided an alternative pattern of the arts to that of the esoteric minority culture of our age. Modern jazz seemed to them to sell the pass: a jazz version of esoteric *avant-garde* music might have its own merits, but they were not the ones they had come to jazz for. Often they were also, and understandably, repelled by the demoralized and asocial atmosphere which frequently surrounded the modernist revolutionaries—the drug taking and peddling, the hipsterdom, and the general atmosphere of a cut-price 1919 Montparnasse. Nor did the fact that commercially-minded men with an eye to the cash value of novelty took up 'bop' as a slogan for 'up-to-date' jazz, encourage them, even though the advertising types failed. In spite of a good deal of American drumbeating in the later forties, 'bop,' 'cool' or 'modern' jazz proved incapable of being turned into a widely saleable music. A 'king of swing' could be built in the 1930s, but not even Mr Woody Herman, who favoured the modern idiom and modern musicians in the later forties, could get himself recognized as 'king of bop'.

Modern jazz won itself a public of sorts, drawn partly from among professional musicians (always ready to appreciate a technically interesting music), partly from among the various national equivalents of the hipsters and St-Germain-type layabouts, partly from among that stratum of young intellectuals, who, as in France, are given to accepting anything in the arts which can plausibly claim to be revolutionary. But it seems pretty clear, in Europe at least, that its major expansion occurred only in the middle and later fifties, when revivalist and traditional jazz had become too widely accepted for comfort. I do not suppose the process was always deliberate. Among musicians in Britain it often took the form of a vague malaise, a boredom with the traditionalist music

whose limits they felt they had explored pretty completely, a desire to play something more interesting. (Characteristically it often took the compromise form of moving from the 'traditional' music of the twenties to the 'mainstream' music of the thirties and early forties, a halfway house to modernism.) But the trend was unmistakable, and it was greatly aided by two American developments: the virtual drying up of the American source of 'traditional' records (except for the perennial blues), and the swelling stream of modern records which British companies either had to release under contract or thought it worth releasing because of the established principle that what sells in America will soon sell in Europe. For in the U.S.A. modern jazz, by the middle fifties, acquired recognized cultural standing, perhaps because the line between hipsterdom and intellectualism grew faint in the period of McCarthy and the apotheosis of General Motors. Where every intellectual risked being an outsider or a secret dissident hidden underneath a crew-cut and grey flannel suit, an outsider's music might well come into its own.

The evolution of the jazz public is no more finished than that of jazz. However, it is not too soon to draw a few general conclusions from its history so far. The first is, that, in spite of considerable national differences, it is surprisingly similar in all countries. It is invariably a predominantly young public, for jazz, with its capacity to express unequivocal emotions in the most direct manner and its gallery of potential heroes and symbols, is a music ideally suited to adolescence. Except perhaps in Britain, the original nucleus of fans always contains a very large element of 'sons of good families', students, and the like, in rebellion against the world and their elders. This is so even in Socialist countries, where jazz (thanks to the official opposition to it) has often become a banner of rebellion for such groups as the *stilyagi* in the U.S.S.R., who are very often the sons of highly placed and conventional parents. Because it is rebellious, the aficionado community finds affinities with movements and ideologies of opposition, and sometimes, as in the Anglo-Saxon countries in the 1930s and after, may become impregnated with it. But normally, being vague and individualist, it remains on the margins of activity, and tends to attract those who want to contract out of convention as much as those who wish to overthrow it. The jazz of the 1920s was non-political; that of the 1930s and 40s

attached itself to the left, and no doubt overlapped a little with its activists, just as it is likely that in some Socialist countries it is vaguely anti-Socialist, and may overlap a little with anti-Socialist activities. But on the whole we shall not expect many fans or amateur trumpet players to build, or perhaps even to man, the barricades. Mostly they will eventually retire into one form or another of official orthodoxy, remembering their turbulent past only as the proverbial young American executive of the post-war films remembers the little Italian girl with whom he had a passionate affair in Rome before returning home to the rat-race and the battle of the sexes.

In Britain (and possibly in other countries about which I am uninformed) the core of the jazz public represented another kind of rebellion, and a more serious one: the aspirations of the culturally and educationally underprivileged young for official recognition. Perhaps this is one reason why its political connexions and activities have been much more persistent here than elsewhere.

Round this nucleus, another wider and vaguer jazz public has emerged, as jazz has become better known. For these young people jazz has been not so much a cause and a banner (though all adolescents make themselves symbols of their separation from their elders), as a fashion and a convention. It is part of their life at a certain age, like playing tennis or going camping or going to espresso bars. There is a wide difference between the atmosphere of the jazz rebel, with his penchant for low life as much as for music, and the atmosphere of the characteristic British mass jazz club of the early and middle 1950s, where nobody drank, or wanted to drink, anything stronger than Coca-Cola, or smoke anything stronger than tobacco, and where the songs about whores, fancy-men, gamblers, and tough men echoed through an atmosphere which was much less like that of Storyville than like that of an old-fashioned youth club, minus the organizers. In a way this sort of public was and is a great deal more like the public jazz was made for than any other. Few jazz occasions recaptured the New Orleans spirit (as distinct from the New Orleans environment) better than the 'river-boat shuffles' or 'jazz carnivals' which came to be organized in Britain: one or two steamers would be hired to go to Margate and back, a selection of bands playing, or relays of musicians would play for an Albert Hall filled

to the brim with working-class adolescents having the time of their lives. By aficionado standards, few of these were serious jazz fans. It was simply that for them jazz had become what Viennese waltzes were for their grandparents, and shimmies or foxtrots for their parents: the normal kind of music for dancing and a good time.

A third form of jazz public (if it can be so called) has also developed round the original nucleus of the fans: those who take no particular interest in jazz, but recognize that it has become part of the cultural scene, and must be treated as such. Jazz has been slow thus to establish itself, except in the Scandinavian countries where (in Denmark at least) jazz classes appear to have been organized in schools, and jazz concerts officially subsidized even in the early 1930s. Even in America official recognition of the fact that jazz is the most original musical contribution to civilization made in that country has been slow. (Fortunately, for it is very doubtful whether jazz flourishes any more than folk-song in an atmosphere of academic music schools and seminars or symphony concerts.) However, little by little the patent appeal of jazz has been reflected in the institutions of orthodox culture. Jazz reviews have appeared in serious journals, jazz programmes on serious broadcasts. At bottom all this amounts to no more than the recognition that jazz is now something about which the well-informed person ought to know enough to hide his ignorance. But even that is something.

Notes

- [1.](#) Blesh and Janis, 188.
- [2.](#) Stearns, 211.
- [3.](#) T. and M. Arnold, *Jazz and the Collector* (*Jazz Review*, London 1945), 18.
- [4.](#) Elliott Paul, *That Crazy Music* (London 1957), 228.
- [5.](#) *Le Jazz Hot*, December 1948.
- [6.](#) Circulation figures from *World's Press News*, 17 October 1958.
- [7.](#) This estimate is based on the capacity of the halls booked by such a band, and on some expert information.
- [8.](#) The material on which these notes are based is sketchy, except for Britain, where I know the scene and the publications best, and have had access to the files of the *National Jazz Federation* (see Appendix One). For France I have had the advantage of conversations with MM. Charles Delaunay, André Hodeir, and J-B. Hess.
- [9.](#) Quoted in Berendt, 12.
- [10.](#) Oxtot, The Yerba Buena Band (*Jazz Review*, London 1945), 12.
- [11.](#) Mezzrow and Wolfe, 5.

- [12.](#) *Ibid.*, 109–10.
- [13.](#) Stearns, 186.
- [14.](#) T. and M. Arnold, *loc. cit.*: an analysis of the readers of *The Record Changer*, the leading collectors' magazine.
- [15.](#) A survey conducted for KHIP station, San Francisco, by Contemporary Research, 1960.
- [16.](#) *Billboard*, 15 August 1960.
- [17.](#) Spike Hughes, *Second Movement*.
- [18.](#) *Melody Maker*, January 1926, 6–7.
- [19.](#) *Rhythm*, April 1939.
- [20.](#) *Western Mail*, 29 March 1958.
- [21.](#) It is certainly true to some extent of France and Germany.

* In America this is ceasing to be the case.

† If the readership of *Downbeat* is typical of U.S. jazz fans, this is not true in America. According to the magazine's readership survey (15 September 1960), sixty-five per cent of its readers own and play two instruments each, while seventy-three per cent describe themselves as amateur musicians; an admirable state of affairs. Incidentally, the unmarried among these young men spent \$172 a year on records, eighty per cent of them jazz, eleven per cent classical, and only nine per cent pops. However, *Downbeat* has always been a musicians' as well as a fans' journal. Even today musicians form the third largest group of its readers (after office-workers and students).

‡ Ninety-two per cent of the readers of *Downbeat* in 1960 were males.

§ As usual, this applies less to the *avant-garde* of 'modern' jazz, whose fringe followers—perhaps less in Britain than in some big American cities—contained a number of declassed types who affected at least sexual ambivalence. See Norman Mailer and the San Francisco 'beat' generation on the hipster. A very few homosexual musicians are known even among the pioneer jazzmen—for instance, Tony Jackson, the brothel pianist of New Orleans who inspired Jelly-Roll Morton—and it is easy to see why the social milieu of night-club jazz would attract them. This only makes the overwhelmingly heterosexual atmosphere of the art more striking. By tradition the jazz musician (and by imitation, the jazz fan) goes for women just like the traditional Italian operatic tenor.

¶ The following is the chart of gramophone record preference in colleges, as reported in *Billboard*, 1960:

Category	All students per cent	Male per cent	Female per cent
Classical	36.8	30.4	51.8
Popular	34.2	27.0	51.2
Jazz	22.3	20.0	27.7
Show	6.0	2.4	14.2
Opera	3.5	3.8	2.6
Semi-classical	2.4	1.4	4.6
Folk	2.1	1.8	2.6
Mood Music	0.8	0.7	1.0

As students recorded more than one preference, the percentages may add up to more than 100. The figures for folk-music are today almost certainly rising. The tendency of the girls to express

multiple preferences (their choices add up to over 150 per cent) makes their taste for jazz a little less impressive than it looks.

|| This produced, among others, Benny Goodman and Ben Pollack.

** Seven European polls between 1937 and 1957, taken in four countries, name Armstrong seven times, Gillespie twice, Miles Davis once. In the same period the American *Metronome* poll chose at least six other trumpeters, not including Armstrong (Berigan, James, Eldridge, Gillespie, Davis, Chet Baker).

†† *Melody Maker* 1927, p. 469. The records published by a small company Levaphone-Oriole included Lil's Hot Shots (Louis Armstrong), Jelly-Roll Morton piano solos, Russell's Hot Six, and others received with marked lack of enthusiasm by the contemporary critic. Still, the publication of such a selection of records in 1927 is itself significant.

‡‡ I have summarized these data from various issues of the *Melody Maker* in 1934 and 1935. The London areas which founded Rhythm Clubs up to the middle of 1935 were: Central London, North Middlesex, Croydon, Forest Gate, Ealing, East Ham, Barking, Richmond, Willesden, Sutton, Walthamstow, Greenwich, Uxbridge, Edgware, Muswell Hill, Lewisham, Edmonton, South Norwood, Carshalton, Hornsey, Wembley, Woodford Green. The student will observe the absence of Rhythm Clubs in Hampstead, Kensington, or Chelsea.

§§ It is not the business of this book to compile statistical tables or social surveys, but the following notes, taken from an analysis of the contributors to a British jazz magazine in the middle forties give a pretty good impression of the atmosphere of this first generation of active fans: (1) draughtsman; (2) free-lance journalist; (3) editor of a Scottish literary journal, poet and writer; (4) 'collector'; (5) journalist; (6) artist; (7) 'has done experimental writing' (subsequently journalist, record-dealer); (8) jazz and dance band journalist, 'student of philosophy'; (9) dance band journalist; (10) agricultural expert, writer for Young Communist journal; (11) small business, 'very interested in literature'; (12) draughtsman, 'interested in literature, art, modern poetry, music'; (13) first wrote on jazz in Young Communist journal; (14) surrealist Bohemian; (15) 'student of American history, sociology, and economics, active in Rhythm Club movement', first wrote on jazz in Young Communist journal; (16) anarchist, 'interested in modern poetry, literature, surrealism, classical music, and Eastern philosophy'; (17) actor and journalist (connected with Communist activities); (18) ex-Cambridge poet; (19) physicist; (20) farmer; (21) doctor; (22) London student; (23) film technician; (24) journalist; (25) free-lance journalist, broadcaster; (26) free-lance (commercial radio scripts, material for Windmill Theatre shows, etc.); (27) surrealist, painter, writer; (28) anarchist journalist, writer (*Jazz Music, passim*).

¶¶ George Webb 1917; Wally Fawkes, Pat Hawes 1920; Humphrey Lyttelton 1921; Cy Laurie, Eric Silk 1926; Ken Colyer, Mick Mulligan 1928; Alex Welsh, Sandy Brown, George Melly, Johnny Parker 1929; Chris Barber 1930; Lonnie Donegan 1931; Otilie Patterson 1932.

|||| See Appendix 1.

*** Intelligent impresarios in the provinces soon learned to time their early performances so as to give the fans a chance to come off shift or after the day's work.

††† By 1960 this situation had improved somewhat.